

Section I: Art Team Management & Pipeline

(Note: - The document contains detailed explanations with reference sources to ensure the research is credible and well supported. Summary has been added after section 2 were explanation is longer)

Question 1: Art Asset Production Pipeline

Google Sheet link:-

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1vklmwW9gayYWUbAlfhGLEy6UB9aVgBZedc7h7kLWTzc/edit?usp=sharing>

Written Explanation

This model breaks down the entire art assets production pipeline for a stylized semi-realistic COD Zombies-themed mobile game with a single map. The aim was to approximate the number of assets, justify it with some genre research, estimate the production time, calculate the number of employees needed, and verify if it is feasible to complete the project and have a soft launch period of 6 months after a 9 month development phase. Everything is formula-based and scalable so that the model can automatically adjust with any changes in the scope.

Asset Quantities and Reasoning :- The asset list was determined by taking apart the design of traditional COD Zombies maps and similar mobile shooters. These shooters usually combine the effects of enemy variation, gun variation, the use of modulated maps, and good graphical effects to ensure game replay value. For instance, the model has 10 basic types of zombies, which matches the 8 to 12 types usually found in Zombies style shooters to avoid graphical repetition when playing long survival missions. Other game characters, like runners, armored zombies, and elemental zombies, and a boss, were used to ensure game progression.

The numbers of guns were also science-based. COD Zombies maps typically have 12-16 guns broken down by pistols, SMGs, ARs, SGs, Snipers, and LMGs. The resources include 14 base guns, each with a Pack a Punch guns resource, totaling 28 gun resources. Environment resources are estimated by a standard Zombies cartography, breaking down into 4-6 main areas on a given map. In this model, five are used: Spawn, Courtyard, Laboratory, Bunker, and Ritual Room. In an aim to facilitate optimal production, 65 modular resources (walls, floors, doors, stairs, debris, barricades) were used, as per standard modular design techniques.

The number of props, VFX, UI, and animation data is based on gameplay necessities. The interactive props, like perk machine props, ammo props, and ritual props, are required for Zombies gameplay style. VFX data is required for elemental zombie gameplay, weapon effects,

and ambiance. UI elements involve HUD, weapon icon, perk icon, and menu screens. The number of animation data is based on the number of zombie types and weapons available.

Total Hours and Staffing Requirements:- The complexity level of each asset and the corresponding hours required per asset were determined by the typical benchmark hours of mobile 3D art production. The total hours required by all assets to produce the artwork required calculations in formulas, which resulted in 7440 hours required for the artwork production.

This workload can now be segmented by the roles in the artistic team, which are assigned percentages by the model: Concept (10%), 3D Character (30%), 3D Environment (25%), VFX (15%), UI (10%), and Animation (10%). Hours for each of the roles can now automatically be calculated. Full-time artists will commit 1440 hours for 9 months (160 hours/month × 9). Using hours needed/hours available for each role gives the total headcount required.

Timeline Feasibility: - The Timeline sheet evaluates the total hours (7440) against the total team capacity (7440). Because the capacity fulfills the need, the model verifies that the art team will be able to accomplish the production task within the 9 month development timeline. However, the soft launch activities will take place within the next 6 months.

Scalability:- The approach is completely formula based. Any asset variable change, type, or hours affects the total hours, resource requirement, and viability of the timeline. This ensures flexibility in the pipeline.

Question 2: Battle Pass Art Strategy Analysis

Analysis Lens	Fortnite (Mobile)	Brawl Stars	Call of Duty: Mobile	Arena Breakout	BGMI
Latest Season Theme	Chapter 6 Season 1 Japanese Mythology (Demons/Dojo) + Disney's Baymax.	Mechmas + Stranger Things Retro 80s Horror meets High-Tech Mecha.	S11: Winter Ops Tactical Winter gear mixed with stylized "Karate/Anime" elements.	Season 3 PMC Streetwear / Gritty Cyberpunk.	A16: Polar Quest Fantasy Ice, Crystal armors, & Penguin Meme Suits.
Art Direction Strategy	"The Metaverse Blender" Radical	"Theme & Variation" Strong central silhouette re-	"Tactical Fantasy" Grounded military	"Grounded Drip" Hyper-realistic	"Maximalist Mythic" High-contrast,

Analysis Lens	Fortnite (Mobile)	Brawl Stars	Call of Duty: Mobile	Arena Breakout	BGMI
	stylistic variety. Cel-shaded anime next to photoreal IP. No cohesion is the goal.	interpreted through a specific IP or distinct style (Mecha).	silhouettes upgraded with sci-fi geometry and glowing emissives.	textures. Vanity items must look functional (e.g., tactical jackets, headsets).	glowing, animated textures designed to pop on mobile screens.
Primary Purchase Driver	Social Expression Skins are avatars for the "Hangout" lobby. "Super Styles" drive late-season retention.	Power Fantasy (Hypercharge) Visuals linked to gameplay power. "I look distinct, I am the carry."	The "Pay-to-Win" Sight Weapon blueprints with cleaner iron sights offer a perceived competitive edge.	Intimidation & Status Gear implies experience. Looking "Elite" strikes fear in a high-stakes environment.	Customization Flex Color-changing "Mythic" outfits allow for unique looks in social lobbies.
Differentiation	Pop-Culture Speed Integrating massive IPs (Disney/Marvel) directly into the pass faster than anyone else.	Character Re-Contextualization Skins change the <i>genre</i> of the character (e.g., Bear \$to\$ Demogorgon).	Asset Density Quantity over singular quality. 4 characters + 5 epics feels like massive value.	Immersion Fidelity Refusal to break the "Hardcore" aesthetic preserves the game's tension.	Regional Tuning Aesthetics specifically tuned for the Indian market's love of bright, flashy status symbols.
Key Visual Hook	Baymax (Big White Silhouette)	Eleven (Stranger Things)	Custom Geometry Iron Sights	The "Cyberpunk" Jacket	Color-Changing Mythic Set

Section II: User Acquisition & Growth

Question 3: High-Performing Gaming Creative Research & Insights

Part A: Research Methodology (Simple, Human Version)

This Research is about understanding what makes recent mobile game ads work for three specific titles:

- Free Fire (Shooter)
- Episode (Dating)
- Merge Mansion (Casual Puzzle / Merge)

The idea was not just to collect examples, but to break them down so we can clearly see how these ads were chosen and why they perform well.

1. How the campaigns were chosen

First, the time frame was limited to roughly the last 6 months wherever possible, focusing on campaigns that were clearly live, visible, and impactful (downloads, revenue, buzz, or case-study worthy).

For each game, campaigns were shortlisted if they:

- Were recent, not old legacy ones.
- Had some sign of real performance impact like spikes in downloads, revenue, or mentions.
- Showed interesting creative ideas like celebrity storytelling, strong narrative hooks, localized themes, etc.
- Had enough public detail to actually analyze them not just a one-line mention.

This is how the research landed on:

- Free Fire's India-focused cricket/event activations and community efforts like Booyah Awards.
- Episode's drama-heavy story clips and video-based UA strategy.
- Merge Mansion's mystery-led Kathy Bates campaign and Japan localization push.

Key references for this section:

Free Fire / May 2025 India & revenue context

<https://blog.insightrackr.com/en/docs/2025-May-Top-Mobile-Games>

Free Fire India market and ranking

<https://sensortower.com/blog/india-mobile-game-insights-2025>

Episode UA & storytelling approach

<https://www.adexchanger.com/mobile/storytelling-app-episode-like-interactive-tv-people-cant-put-phones/>

Merge Mansion celebrity & creative direction

<https://www.elixirr.com/en-us/case-studies/metacore-up-levelling-mobile-game-creative-for-millennial-women/>

<https://www.apptamin.com/blog/merge-mansion-and-grandmas-secrets-why-is-it-so-effective%E2%8E%AE-case-study/>

General Kathy Bates / viral campaigns context

<https://www.liquidandgrit.com/app-development/merge-mansions-viral-ad-campaigns/>

2. What sources were used

To avoid a one-sided view, the research combined data tools, case studies, blogs, and formal research:

1. Market and ad data tools

- Used for numbers like: daily active users, downloads, retention, revenue trends, and ad format distribution.
- Also used to see which networks and formats are most used (rewarded video vs full-screen vs playables).

2. Official and agency case studies

- These explain the “why” behind big campaigns in plain language:
 - BBH’s Free Fire “Battle in Style” brand platform and virtual concert work.
 - Metacore and partners on how they repositioned Merge Mansion for millennial women and localized for Japan.

3. Industry blogs and performance guides

- Mobile marketing blogs and tools that publish examples of top-performing creatives, trends like UGC, hook tactics, and playable ads.

4. Regulatory and academic material

- Used to understand risks around fake gameplay advertising and how people actually watch and interact with mobile video ads.

Key references for this section:

Free Fire “Battle in Style” / brand campaign

<https://lbbonline.com/news/bbh-unveils-global-brand-campaign-live-concert-and-anthem-for-free-fire-game>

<https://www.campaignasia.com/video/bbh-traverses-real-and-game-worlds-for-garenas-free-fire-global-campaign/474560>

Merge Mansion creative & millennial women positioning

<https://www.elixirr.com/en-us/case-studies/metacore-up-levelling-mobile-game-creative-for-millennial-women/>

Merge Mansion ad formats and networks

<https://appgrowing.net/blog/en/merge-mansion/>

Puzzle/ad spy & creative intel example

<https://appgrowing.net/blog/en/puzzle-games-marketing/>

Video ad effectiveness / mobile interactive video

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9568838/>

Fake gameplay rulings & controversy

<https://www.mishcon.com/news/asa-rules-mobile-game-ad-was-misleading-gameplay-depicted-did-not-reflect-the-core-game-playing-exp>

<https://www.apptamin.com/blog/video-ads-with-fake-gameplay-why-do-they-work-and-will-they-stick-around/>

Industry trends & benchmarks

<https://playablemaker.com/mobile-game-ad-trends-2025/>

<https://segwise.ai/blog/mobile-game-advertising-insights-best-practices>

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/user-generated-content>

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/mobile-game-ads>

<https://tenjin.com/blog/ad-mon-gaming-2025/>

<https://www.bcg.com/publications/2025/video-gaming-report-2026-next-era-of-growth>

3. How each ad was broken down

After picking the campaigns, each creative was viewed through the same simple pattern so they could be compared across genres:

- Hook (first 3–4 seconds) :- Attention span of the audience
What happens immediately on screen: big movement, shocking drama, a curious question, a character speaking directly to the viewer, etc. This matters because attention drops fast, and strong hooks keep people watching.
- Story and emotion
Does the ad show:
 - Straight gameplay,
 - A mini story (mystery, relationship conflict, dramatic situation), or What is Grandma hiding ?
 - A character's emotional choice?
Episode and Merge Mansion heavily lean into drama, mystery, and emotional decisions, while Free Fire mixes action with event hype.
- Visual / production style
Live action, CGI, in engine renders, or UGC-style footage. For example:
 - Merge Mansion uses high-end live action with Kathy Bates for "What is Grandma Hiding?"
 - Many high-performing mobile ads now intentionally look like TikToks or home-shot content for authenticity.
- Format and placement
Whether the creative is a rewarded video, full-screen video, playable, TikTok/Reel-style short, or in-feed social video, and which networks it runs on (e.g., Meta, AdMob, etc.).
- Call to action (CTA)
"Download now", "Try to solve this", "What would you choose?", "Join before the event ends" often tied to time limited events, collabs or rewards.

- Localization and audience fit
How tailored the creative is to a market:
 - Free Fire: cricket themes + Hindi content for India.
 - Merge Mansion: Japanese actress, local TV spots, and culturally sensitive messaging for Japan.

Key references for this section:

Hook and 3–4 second best practices

<https://appagent.com/blog/hooked-the-secret-to-captivating-mobile-video-ads-in-4-seconds/>

<https://mobidictum.com/playable-factory-launches-introhook/>

Storytelling and narrative in mobile game ads

<https://www.apptamin.com/blog/boost-your-mobile-games-video-ads-thanks-to-storytelling/>

<https://playablemaker.com/examples-of-mobile-game-ads/>

Episode story/drama-led ad strategy

<https://www.adexchanger.com/mobile/storytelling-app-episode-like-interactive-tv-people-cant-put-phones/>

Merge Mansion mystery & Grandma positioning

<https://www.apptamin.com/blog/merge-mansion-and-grandmas-secrets-why-is-it-so-effective%E2%8E%AE-case-study/>

Merge Mansion formats & networks

<https://appgrowing.net/blog/en/merge-mansion/>

Merge Mansion celebrity / Kathy Bates impact

<https://www.elixirr.com/en-us/case-studies/metacore-up-levelling-mobile-game-creative-for-millennial-women/>

UGC / TikTok-native style

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/user-generated-content>

Free Fire India / creative push & revenue

<https://blog.insightrackr.com/en/docs/2025-May-Top-Mobile-Games>

<https://sensortower.com/blog/india-mobile-game-insights-2025>

Merge Mansion Japan localization

<https://www.pocketgamer.biz/how-metacore-cracked-japans-mobile-market-with-merge-mansion/>

4. How success was measured

Because not every campaign shares full internal data, success was read using a mix of public numbers, strong signals, and standard benchmarks:

- Direct public data (when available)
 - Free Fire: daily active players, revenue, and retention (Day 1, Day 7, Day 30).
 - Merge Mansion:
 - ~100% increase in downloads and search volume from the Kathy Bates campaign.
 - 460% surge in social mentions and 82M PR impressions.
 - 138% revenue spike on the last day of one event.
- Strong signals / proxies
 - Being featured in case studies and industry write-ups as a “standout” campaign.
 - Noticeable spikes in brand search, social mentions, and long-running creative investment.
 - High share of spend on particular formats (e.g., a lot of rewarded video usually means it’s working).
- External benchmarks
 - Industry reports were used for typical ranges of CTR, CPI, ROAS, completion rates, etc., and to sanity-check what “good” looks like in mobile game advertising.

Key references for this section:

Free Fire players, retention & revenue

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/free-fire-player-count>

Free Fire India performance & ranking

<https://sensortower.com/blog/india-mobile-game-insights-2025>

<https://blog.insightrackr.com/en/docs/2025-May-Top-Mobile-Games>

Merge Mansion Kathy Bates campaign impact

<https://www.elixirr.com/en-us/case-studies/metacore-up-levelling-mobile-game-creative-for-millennial-women/>

Merge Mansion viral campaigns & downloads

<https://www.liquidandgrit.com/app-development/merge-mansions-viral-ad-campaigns/>

Merge Mansion live events & revenue uplift

<https://liftoff.io/blog/metacore-merge-mansion-live-event-strategy/>

Merge Mansion formats, rewarded video share, networks

<https://appgrowing.net/blog/en/merge-mansion/>

Ad monetization & eCPM benchmarks

<https://tenjin.com/blog/ad-mon-gaming-2025/>

Overall mobile game ad best practices & metrics

<https://segwise.ai/blog/mobile-game-advertising-insights-best-practices>

<https://playablemaker.com/mobile-game-ad-trends-2025/>

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/mobile-game-ads>

5. How cross-genre insights were pulled together

After breaking down campaigns for all three games, the last step was to zoom out and look for patterns:

- Comparing Free Fire, Episode, and Merge Mansion on:
 - Hook style
 - Story vs gameplay balance
 - Visual/production style
 - Formats (rewarded, full-screen, playable, social)
 - Localization depth
- Checking these patterns against 2025 industry trends, such as:
 - The rise of UGC and influencer-driven creatives.
 - AI being used to rapidly test variations and personalize creatives.
 - The shift from simple gameplay demos to narrative-driven, episodic ad series.
- Validating that the observations seen in these three games were echoed in independent reports, not just brand-owned stories.

Key references for this section:

UGC performance & influencer role

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/user-generated-content>

<https://www.grynow.in/blog/influencer-marketing-in-the-gaming-industry.html>

AI and creative trends

<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/gaming-creative-trends-actually-convert-2025-appalgo-l-t-d-0xlmf>

<https://segwise.ai/blog/mobile-targeting-best-practices>

<https://mobidictum.com/playable-factory-launches-introhook/>

Playable ads & mid-2025 review

<https://appagent.com/blog/the-state-of-playable-ads-in-2025-mid-year-strategic-review/>

General mobile game ad trends & best practices

<https://playablemaker.com/mobile-game-ad-trends-2025/>

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/mobile-game-ads>

<https://www.bcg.com/publications/2025/video-gaming-report-2026-next-era-of-growth>

Part B: Campaign Analysis by Genre

This section explains what each game did in its ads, in simple language, and why those campaigns worked.

1. Free Fire (Shooter)

Free Fire's marketing leans heavily on events, culture, and community, especially in India. The creatives are fast, loud, and closely tied to what players already love in real life.

a) Cricket Event Push – “Battle on Cricket Island” (India, 2025)

For India, Free Fire used cricket as its main hook during the IPL season. Creatives and in-game content were built around a cricket-themed event.

What the ads did:

- Showed cricket imagery plus action gameplay – outfits, stadium vibes, and big, energetic scenes.
- Used Hindi language and Indian cultural cues so the ads felt local, not generic.
- Ran a very high number of creatives (around 150 per day) with ~90% targeted at India during peak time.

Why it worked:

- Cricket is an emotional topic in India, so tying the game to IPL made the ads instantly relevant.
- Local language and references made players feel the game “belongs” in their culture, not just imported content.

Reference links:

Free Fire India / May 2025 performance and creatives

<https://blog.insightrackr.com/en/docs/2025-May-Top-Mobile-Games>

India mobile game market context (Free Fire ranking, downloads)

<https://sensortower.com/blog/india-mobile-game-insights-2025>

b) Booyah Awards 2025 – Community & Creators

The Booyah Awards 2025 centered on players and creators, not just the game itself. It had an offline event and lots of social content around it.

What the ads did:

- Highlighted real people – streamers, creators, and community moments, often in Hindi or local flavor.
- Used short social videos and Reels to show hype, winners, behind-the-scenes clips, and celebrations.

Why it worked:

- Turned Free Fire into a community and lifestyle brand, not just an app.
- Gave creators and players a reason to post, share, and talk about the game themselves.

Reference links:

Booyah Awards / India creative and context

<https://blog.insightrackr.com/en/docs/2025-May-Top-Mobile-Games>

Booyah Awards 2025 Instagram promo

<https://www.instagram.com/p/DKjdfEHMwJ-/>

Extra India/Free Fire social hype example

<https://www.instagram.com/reel/DLLC6nSh2f2/>

c) KFC Thailand Collaboration

In Thailand, Free Fire partnered with KFC, blending fast food and gaming into one playful collaboration.

What the ads did:

- Promoted in-game items and visuals themed around KFC, showcased in video ads and social posts.
- Framed the collab as a limited-time event, clearly spelling out dates and urgency.

Why it worked:

- A big mainstream brand like KFC brings attention even from people who don't usually play shooters.
- The lighthearted, food-themed crossover softened the "hardcore" shooter edge and made the game feel fun and approachable.

Reference link:

Free Fire x KFC Thailand campaign breakdown

<https://marketech-apac.com/thailands-gamers-get-a-taste-of-kfc-in-new-free-fire-collaboration-campaign/>

2. Episode (Dating Sim / Interactive Stories)

Episode sells fantasy, drama, and choices rather than graphics. Its strongest ads feel like short emotional scenes from a TV show where the viewer gets to decide what happens.

a) Drama-Based Story Clips & Video Ads

Episode's core user acquisition is built around short, dramatic clips that show big emotional moments from its stories.

What the ads did:

- Showed tense or juicy situations (cheating, breakups, danger, secrets) and then paused to show choices like "Run away" vs. "Confront them".
- Positioned the app as "like Netflix but interactive", with Hollywood-style storytelling tailored to mobile.
- Shifted budget away from simple banners towards video ads and some playable ad experiments.

Why it worked:

- Directly tapped into viewers' emotional curiosity: "What would I do in that situation?"
- Matched how the target audience (mostly young women) already use their phones: snackable, story-based content.

Reference link:

Episode storytelling & UA strategy interview

<https://www.adexchanger.com/mobile/storytelling-app-episode-like-interactive-tv-people-cant-put-phones/>

b) TikTok & Short-Form Story Previews

On TikTok and similar platforms, Episode uses short clips that look like native content.

What the ads did:

- Created 15–30 second vertical story previews ending right before the outcome is revealed.
- Encouraged comments, reactions, and duets as people debated what the "right" choice should be.

Why it worked:

- Relationship drama and POV stories already perform well on TikTok, so Episode fits into that culture naturally.
- The ads feel more like content you'd watch anyway, not a traditional ad.

Reference links:

Episode design & narrative talk (useful for context)

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1Rq2oErDEmA>

Episode-related TikTok content hub

<https://www.tiktok.com/discover/episode-game>

c) Influencers & Dating-Style Marketing

Episode also quietly benefits from broader dating app and relationship content marketing.

What the ads/content did:

- Partnered with influencers in lifestyle, relationships, and beauty niches to talk about "addictive interactive stories" they're playing.

- Used soft, story-first selling: creators share crazy or emotional storylines rather than just “download this app”.

Why it worked:

- Blended into the existing dating/relationship conversation online instead of feeling like a separate, pushy ad.
- Leveraged trust and relatability from creators, which is especially powerful for a young, female-skewing audience.

Reference links:

Dating/dating-app style marketing strategies

<https://favoured.co.uk/innovative-dating-app-marketing-strategies-for-2025/>

<https://hobo.video/blog/dating-app-marketing-guide-for-2025-strategies-to-attract-new-users/>

3. Merge Mansion (Casual Puzzle)

Merge Mansion is technically a puzzle/merge game, but its most famous ads look more like trailers for a mystery TV show. That contrast is exactly what makes them memorable.

a) “What is Grandma Hiding?” – Kathy Bates Live-Action Campaign

This campaign is a standout example of using celebrity and story in mobile game marketing.

What the ads did:

- Cast Kathy Bates as the mysterious grandma and built full live-action scenes around her.
- Focused on suspense and family secrets, with very little direct gameplay shown.
- Repeated the central mystery line “What is Grandma hiding?” until it became a recognizable meme.

Why it worked:

- Completely broke the pattern of typical puzzle ads, so people remembered it.
- Generated conversation and curiosity well beyond the game’s core audience.
- Delivered hard results: big increases in downloads, search volume, social mentions, and PR impressions.

Reference links:

Kathy Bates / millennial women case study

<https://www.elixirr.com/en-us/case-studies/metacore-up-levelling-mobile-game-creative-for-millennial-women/>

Why the Grandma/mystery creative is effective

<https://www.apptamin.com/blog/merge-mansion-and-grandmas-secrets-why-is-it-so-effective%E2%8E%AE-case-study/>

Extra breakdown of Merge Mansion viral campaigns

<https://www.liquidandgrit.com/app-development/merge-mansions-viral-ad-campaigns/>

b) Japan Hyper-Localized Campaign

In Japan, the team re-imagined their marketing specifically for that market instead of just translating their global ads.

What the ads did:

- Featured Nagisa Shibuya, a Japanese actress/influencer, to front the campaign.
- Localized every major touchpoint – TV ads, social creatives, app store assets, and a limited-time in-game offer designed for that market.
- Carefully reviewed copy and visuals to ensure they felt polite, appropriate, and culturally comfortable for Japanese users.

Why it worked:

- Showed respect and understanding of local culture, which builds long-term trust.
- Produced measurable improvements in installs, brand consideration, and search volume in Japan.

Reference link:

Japan campaign and localization story

<https://www.pocketgamer.biz/how-metacore-cracked-japans-mobile-market-with-merge-mansion/>

c) Live Events & Revenue-Driven Ads

Merge Mansion also uses live events to drive both engagement and spending, supported by smart ad messaging.

What the ads did:

- Promoted special events like “Merge it Up!” (mini battle pass) where merging during the event unlocks rewards, with a paid premium track available.
- Used ads to clearly communicate limited time and “don’t miss the rewards” messaging.

Why it worked:

- Live events give players a fresh reason to come back and spend, beyond the core loop.
- Some events correlated with very strong revenue spikes, showing how event-focused creatives can impact monetization.

Reference links:

Live event strategy & revenue uplift

<https://liftoff.io/blog/metacore-merge-mansion-live-event-strategy/>

Ad formats and network breakdown for Merge Mansion

<https://appgrowing.net/blog/en/merge-mansion/>

Part C: Key Insights (Human, Cross-Genre)

1. The first 3–4 seconds decide everything

Across shooter, dating, and puzzle, the opening seconds of the ad were critical.

What works well:

- Instant movement or surprise: explosions, sudden close-ups, dramatic entrances.
- A sharp emotional moment: a betrayal scene in Episode, a shocking reveal in Merge Mansion.
- A simple curiosity hook: “What is Grandma hiding?”, “Would you pick him or her?”, “Can you survive this?”.

Why it matters:

- People scroll fast; if the hook is weak, they never see the rest of your story.
- Tests and industry research show strong hooks greatly improve watch-through and overall performance.

Reference links:

Hook best practices and attention in first seconds

<https://appagent.com/blog/hooked-the-secret-to-captivating-mobile-video-ads-in-4-seconds/>

<https://mobidictum.com/playable-factory-launches-introhook/>

2. Story and emotion beat raw gameplay

A clear pattern emerges: good ads sell the fantasy and emotion first, gameplay second.

How each game shows this:

- Free Fire: events, lifestyle, collabs, and community moments – not only kills and stats.
- Episode: relationship drama and life situations, with players choosing how things unfold.
- Merge Mansion: full-blown mystery trailer energy with Grandma as the star.

Why it works:

- People emotionally connect more with characters and situations than with UI screens.
- Once the emotional hook is in place, gameplay is easier to sell as the way to “live that story”.

Reference links:

Storytelling in mobile game video ads

<https://www.apptamin.com/blog/boost-your-mobile-games-video-ads-thanks-to-storytelling/>

Examples of story-first high-performing mobile ads

<https://playablemaker.com/examples-of-mobile-game-ads/>

Broader mobile game ad creative trends

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/mobile-game-ads>

3. UGC and influencer-style creatives are winning

Across mobile gaming, UGC-style ads and influencer content perform extremely well.

What this looks like:

- Ads that look like someone filming in their bedroom, not a glossy studio.
- Split-screen formats showing a real person reacting while gameplay runs.
- Creators sharing “I got addicted to this game because...” instead of reading a script.

Why it works:

- Feels more like a friend’s recommendation than an ad.
- Platforms like TikTok and Instagram reward authentic-looking content.

Reference links:

Why UGC dominates mobile game ads

<https://www.blog.udonis.co/mobile-marketing/mobile-games/user-generated-content>

Influencer marketing in gaming

<https://www.grynow.in/blog/influencer-marketing-in-the-gaming-industry.html>

Creative trends that actually convert

<https://playablemaker.com/mobile-game-ad-trends-2025/>

4. Deep localization > simple translation

The strongest global campaigns didn't just translate text – they rebuilt the creative for each market.

Examples:

- Free Fire: cricket themes, Hindi copy, India-only events and awards.
- Merge Mansion: Japanese celebrity, localized messaging, and tailored offers for Japan.

Why it works:

- Makes the game feel truly “for us” in each country, not just a generic global product.
- Avoids cultural missteps and builds long-term brand love.

Reference links:

Free Fire India (events and performance context)

<https://blog.insightrackr.com/en/docs/2025-May-Top-Mobile-Games>

<https://sensortower.com/blog/india-mobile-game-insights-2025>

Merge Mansion Japan localization story

<https://www.pocketgamer.biz/how-metacore-cracked-japans-mobile-market-with-merge-mansion/>

5. AI + constant testing are becoming standard

Behind many of these campaigns is a process of continuous creative testing, increasingly powered by AI tools.

What's happening:

- Generating many versions of hooks, captions, visuals, and then seeing which ones perform best.
- Adapting creatives to different player segments (e.g., payers vs. non-payers, casual vs. competitive).
- Letting dynamic systems automatically pick which creative to show to whom.

Why it matters:

- The winners are not just the most creative teams, but also the ones who test, learn, and iterate fastest.
- AI is becoming a practical tool for speeding up this cycle.

Reference links:

Gaming creative trends & AI-driven testing

<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/gaming-creative-trends-actually-convert-2025-appalgo-l-t-d-0xlmf>

Mobile targeting & dynamic creative optimization

<https://segwise.ai/blog/mobile-targeting-best-practices>

Mid-2025 playable ads review (performance & trends)

<https://appagent.com/blog/the-state-of-playable-ads-in-2025-mid-year-strategic-review/>

Hook generation tools (IntroHook)

<https://mobidictum.com/playable-factory-launches-introhook/>

6. Simple playbook you can reuse

Putting it all together, a simple, practical playbook emerges from these three games:

- Grab attention in the first 3–4 seconds with movement, shock, or a direct emotional moment.
- Lead with a story or feeling, not just UI and features.
- Mix in UGC/influencer-style ads for authenticity and better performance on social platforms.
- Go beyond translation: localize concepts, faces, and themes for key markets.
- Treat creatives as living experiments – test, learn, and iterate with data (and AI where possible).

Reference links (broad trend support):

Global gaming growth & creative trends

<https://www.bcg.com/publications/2025/video-gaming-report-2026-next-era-of-growth>

Mobile game ad insights & best practices

<https://segwise.ai/blog/mobile-game-advertising-insights-best-practices>

<https://playablemaker.com/mobile-game-ad-trends-2025/>

A brief key insights document that synthesizes cross-genre trends, creative strategies, and lessons from your research

1. Hooks Decide Whether the Ad Even Gets a Chance

The first 3–4 seconds of an ad consistently determine whether anyone will see the rest. In all three genres, the most successful creatives opened with either high-motion visuals, a sharp emotional moment, or a strong curiosity line. Free Fire uses fast action or big event visuals (e.g., cricket stadium energy or explosive sequences); Episode jumps straight into a tense relationship situation; Merge Mansion hits viewers with an unsettling or mysterious

shot of Grandma and her secrets. Once attention is secured, the rest of the ad can afford to slow down and explain, but without that initial jolt, even a brilliant narrative will be ignored.

A key lesson is to design creatives “hook-first,” not “story-first” or “asset-first.” Teams should prototype multiple alternative openings for the same concept different first lines, different first shots and test which version keeps viewers past the 3–4 second mark before investing heavily in full production.

2. Story and Emotion Beat Raw Gameplay

Across all three titles, the strongest ads sell the *fantasy* and *emotion* of the game, not the mechanics. Episode’s marketing leans into interactive TV language and showcases dramatic choices rather than UI; viewers are invited to imagine themselves in messy, high-stakes social situations. Merge Mansion goes even further and almost hides the gameplay behind a live-action mystery that feels like a streaming show trailer. Free Fire, although a competitive shooter, foregrounds lifestyle, community, and events (like cricket collaborations and awards shows) instead of only killstreaks and rank climbs.

The takeaway is that most players don’t install because a HUD looks nice; they install because they want to *feel* something specific powerful, desired, clever, included, or curious. Ads that clearly dramatize that feeling through characters, stakes, and mini-narratives generally outperform straightforward gameplay montages, especially in crowded genres.

3. Authenticity and UGC Are Now Core, Not Extra

User-generated and influencer-style content is no longer a side experiment; it has become a core performance engine in mobile game advertising. Creatives that look like real players filming at home, split-screen reaction formats, and informal “this game got me hooked” testimonials consistently deliver strong engagement and lower acquisition costs compared with highly polished, obviously scripted ads.

What connects Free Fire community content, Episode’s creator-driven dating narratives, and broader UGC trends is a shift away from authoritative brand voice toward peer voice. Viewers increasingly trust what looks like genuine player experience more than what looks like a traditional TV spot, even when they intellectually know creators are sponsored. For marketing teams, this means building systems and budgets to continuously brief, source, and iterate UGC and creator content treating it as a mainline channel, not a small experiment.

4. Deep Localization Outperforms Simple Translation

Free Fire's cricket-driven India push and Merge Mansion's Japan strategy show how deeply localized creative can transform performance. Instead of reusing global assets with subtitles, these campaigns started from local culture: cricket as a national passion in India; local celebrities, norms, and politeness expectations in Japan. Language, casting, references, and even event calendars were tailored to each market.

The lesson is that localization should be treated as creative strategy, not just language operations. Teams should ask: "What is the emotional entry point for this country?" and "Who and what signals feel truly local here?" That may mean different story angles, different hooks, or entirely new hero spots by region. This is particularly impactful for genres like dating sims and casual puzzle games that rely heavily on emotional and cultural resonance.

5. Formats Are Converging Around Video, Events, and Interactivity

Across genres, high-performing campaigns clustered around a small set of format patterns: short vertical video (especially for social and stories), rewarded or full-screen video in UA channels, and, for more complex games, selectively used playables. Merge Mansion shows how video ads can be used to support live events and revenue spikes, while Free Fire demonstrates how offline or in-game events (Booyah Awards, sports tie-ins) give the creative team fresh narrative beats to advertise.

Rather than chasing every new placement, the winning approach is to specialize in a few core formats and get very good at matching message to context for example, fast emotional hooks for social video, clearer value propositions and CTA for rewarded placements, and deeper demos or story arcs for longer-form or re-engagement formats.

6. Creative Is a Continuous Experiment, Increasingly Powered by Data and AI

A final cross-genre insight is that none of these campaigns looks like a one off bet. Behind each is a mindset of continuous creative testing: new hooks, new storylines, new character angles, and new event tie-ins. The industry is moving toward treating creative as an iterative product, with data (and increasingly AI tools) guiding which variant to scale and which to retire.

For teams, that means designing processes where concepts can be rapidly prototyped, cut into multiple versions, tested in small budgets, and then scaled up once winners emerge. It also means structuring briefs around hypotheses ("Will a relationship dilemma hook outperform a generic power fantasy?") rather than around fixed "final" assets.

Part B: Application of Insights for Lila Games

LILA Black (Casual Extraction Shooter)

LILA Black sits in a really interesting space: it is an extraction shooter, but positioned as more accessible, fast, and mobile friendly than the very hardcore PC titles. That means the creative can lean into tension and high stakes, but still feel fun and approachable, similar to how Free Fire balances intensity with style and community.

1. “One Run, One Decision”

Idea: Ads built around a single, high pressure decision in a match. For example: the squad has the cube, alarms are going off, and you have to decide whether to push for extra loot or extract now.

Why this makes sense:

- Extraction as a genre lives on that risk versus reward moment. Showing that moment explicitly is like the shooter version of Episode’s “what would you choose?” scenes and Merge Mansion’s “what is Grandma hiding?” hook.
- The first few seconds can open with a simple question on screen or as a voice line: “You have 10 seconds. Do you run or stay?” That follows the strong hook pattern that high performing mobile ads use to keep people watching beyond second three.

Why it could perform:

- It is instantly understandable even for players who have never tried extraction shooters before. They do not need to know all systems to feel the tension of that choice.
- It sells the feeling of the game (making clutch calls, living with the consequences) which, as seen with Free Fire and Merge Mansion, tends to convert better than just showing UI and weapon stats.

2. “Casual Tarkov” Positioning

Idea: Creatives that lean into the idea of “extraction, but less punishing,” highlighting that LILA Black is built for mobile sessions, with clear objectives and readable maps, but still with meaningful loss if you fail.

Why this makes sense:

- Commentary around extraction shooters shows a perception that they are extremely hardcore and stressful. At the same time, LILA Black's own positioning stresses "fast, tactical, accessible FPS" on mobile.
- There is a clear gap between hyper hardcore PC extraction experiences and more approachable mobile shooters like Free Fire. Filling that gap is a strong differentiator.

Why it could perform:

- It speaks directly to a large group of players who are curious about extraction but intimidated by full loss of progress and complexity.
- It mirrors what Merge Mansion did for puzzle: take a familiar genre, but reframe it with a very different emotional and creative angle to stand out.

3. Contract Missions as Mini Episodes

Idea: Each ad focuses on one contract type (for example Uplink, Deliver Payload, Protect Package, Boss Bot), and treats it like a short mission story: "Tonight's contract: protect the package, extract alive."

Why this makes sense:

- LILA Black already has distinct mission types, which naturally lend themselves to episodic storytelling.
- In the research, episodic framing worked very well for Merge Mansion and Episode: each ad felt like another piece of a bigger story, not a random montage.

Why it could perform:

- It helps onboard new players by showing clearly "this is the kind of objective you will get," without overwhelming them.
- It also gives you a structure for live operations: when you push a new contract type or event, you can build a mini series of ads around that, similar to how Merge Mansion used live events to drive spikes in engagement and revenue.

4. Squad UGC and "We Almost Lost Everything" Moments

Idea: UGC style ads recorded like a friend's vertical screen capture plus voice, where a squad is yelling, laughing, and panicking as they barely make it to extraction or lose all their loot at the last second.

Why this makes sense:

- Extraction shooters are very social. The emotional peak is often shared with friends in voice chat, not just experienced alone.
- In the research, user generated content and influencer style creatives consistently delivered better engagement and lower costs than highly polished, brand only ads.

Why it could perform:

- It feels like someone you know is showing you a crazy moment from last night, which matches the mobile UGC and TikTok aesthetic that players respond to.
- It shows the stakes and systems indirectly through real reactions, so you do not need heavy explanations of every mechanic.

5. “From Naked to Kitted” Progression Ads

Idea: Before and after style creatives where a character starts with basic gear and, over several successful runs, ends up in fully customized, premium looking loadouts.

Why this makes sense:

- The store listing and dev content highlight progression, crafting, and customization as core parts of LILA Black.
- Ads that show visual transformation over time are a proven way to communicate long term payoff in a few seconds, across multiple game genres.

Why it could perform:

- It taps into the status fantasy: “if I keep playing and extracting, I will look and feel like this.”
- It can be combined with the UGC approach, for example a creator walking through “this is how my account looked on day 1 versus now,” which aligns with best practices around authentic creator led storytelling.

6. Local “Legendary Run” Stories

Idea: For key markets, build localized ads where a named, local style character narrates their “legendary run” in their own language and slang, with clips of gameplay and extraction in the background.

Why this makes sense:

- Free Fire’s success in India came from going beyond translation: cricket integrations, local awards shows, and Hindi content made the game feel native.

- Merge Mansion's Japan campaign showed how using a local celebrity and culturally sensitive creative led to large lifts in installs and brand metrics.

Why it could perform:

- It makes LILA Black feel like "our" game in each region, not just a global title ported to mobile.
 - It pairs very well with influencer and UGC strategies, because local creators can put their own spin on the "legendary run" format.
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Heart's Desire (Dating Sim)

Heart's Desire is much closer to Episode in its core fantasy: interactive romance, secrets, and choices that lead to different endings. That means a lot of the Episode and drama based learnings transfer almost directly.

1. "One Choice, Two Outcomes"

Idea: Ads that freeze on a big decision, then quickly show two radically different outcomes side by side. For example, trusting a character versus confronting them, leading to either a sweet moment or a dramatic fallout.

Why this makes sense:

- The game's copy strongly emphasizes that every choice changes the story and leads to unexpected outcomes.
- Episode's most effective creatives focused on "what would you choose" at moments of high drama, not on quiet scenes.

Why it could perform:

- It packs the core value proposition into a very short format: "your choices really matter here."
- It creates a natural urge to comment and debate, similar to how choice based ads perform on social platforms.

2. "She Has a Secret" Character Trailers

Idea: Short character spotlights that introduce a love interest, hint at her personality, then end by teasing a secret or twist: "But there is something she is not telling you."

Why this makes sense:

- Heart's Desire promises that every woman has her own personality, secrets, and dreams.
- Merge Mansion showed how a single central mystery question can drive a whole campaign; here, each character can carry her own mini mystery.

Why it could perform:

- It builds attachment to individual characters before players even install, which is key for narrative games where character connection drives retention.
- It gives you a framework to build a whole series of creatives around, without reinventing the structure each time.

3. TikTok Style "POV You Messed Up" Clips

Idea: Vertical, meme friendly clips framed as "POV you picked the wrong option," with quick cuts of escalating drama and bad outcomes.

Why this makes sense:

- POV and relationship drama content already thrives on TikTok and Reels.
- Episode and other story games naturally fit into these formats because they can present scenes almost like mini skits.

Why it could perform:

- It looks and feels like normal content on those platforms, so it is less likely to be skipped immediately.
- The concept is easy to localize and endlessly remix using different situations and characters.

4. Chat Thread Stories

Idea: Ads that play out entirely as a text chat between the player and a love interest, where a confession, argument, or reveal happens.

Why this makes sense:

- Players are used to reading chat screens on mobile, so there is almost no cognitive friction; they instantly understand what is happening.
- Many dating and story games successfully use chat style creatives to convey drama and interactivity without complex visuals.

Why it could perform:

- It is cheap to produce, easy to test in many variants, and highly readable even on small screens.

- It clearly signals “your replies matter” which is the heart of the gameplay.

5. Male Narrator UGC: “This Went Way Further Than I Expected”

Idea: Creator style ads where a male narrator casually talks about starting Heart’s Desire as a simple romance game, but then getting wrapped into more intense drama and secrets than expected.

Why this makes sense:

- The product can appeal to male audiences who like interactive drama and multiple romance possibilities, not just a purely female audience.
- UGC style testimonials have been particularly strong for mobile games overall, especially when the tone is honest and slightly self deprecating.

Why it could perform:

- It humanizes the game and addresses possible skepticism head on without feeling defensive.
- It is easy to run many variations with different creators, which aligns with current best practices of testing lots of UGC angles.

6. “City of Choices” Lifestyle Montage

Idea: Ads that focus less on individual dialogues and more on the overall lifestyle fantasy: city views, dates, nightlife, fashion, and a sense of exploring a living world of relationships.

Why this makes sense:

- The game copy invites players to enjoy a city, relax, and experience different paths and adventures, not just static conversations.
- Free Fire and Merge Mansion both benefited from selling their world and atmosphere, not just the core mechanics.

Why it could perform:

- It can attract users who are more interested in escapism, travel, and aspirational experiences than in pure “waifu collector” framing.

This type of creative has potential to support higher value segments, as seen in other narrative and lifestyle oriented games.